CBI awaited us with handcuffs.

SOLID, LIQUID AND A LOT OF GAS

'The name Sarabhai could move heaven and earth.'

For the common man, space science has been a matter of either wide-eyed wonder or just a waste of money. Almost four decades after Vikram Sarabhai dreamt of making India a space power, we are almost there, but ISRO has not convinced everyone that the toil of so many scientists and the support the organisation got from the government have not gone in vain. India today is among the best satellite launching nations, and is on a promising trajectory towards deep space probes and interplanetary explorations.

What most of the world outside ISRO doesn't know is that this versatile group of scientists and engineers were at loggerheads, more often than not to push for what they thought was better for rocketry and the country. ISRO has been steeped in internal politics, but much of it was battle of ideas, at least in the earlier years.

As early as 1967, I had pushed for liquid propulsion. This was not easy because the Indian space programme then was revolving solely around solid propulsion. Moreover, Sarabhai, an astrophysicist, himself was either not convinced of the capabilities of liquid propulsion or our capabilities to develop it. It was widely accepted that liquid propulsion could send heavier rockets to space, but it was tougher than playing with solid fuels. Now nobody contests that it is the Vikas engine—which I was instrumental in developing—which is at the core of Indian space's work horse PSLV which has had thirty-eight consecutively successful launches till July 2017.

Sarabhai had another pet dream—developing long-range missiles. And he thought missiles have to be built with solid fuel. At the risk of sounding immodest, I would say that I had to educate Sarabhai on this. I plunged into rocket science literature and pored over international project reports